

Session 8: Food Sacrificed to Idols

Key Takeaways

- Paul addresses two different situations of “strong” and “weak” followers of Jesus in Rome and Corinth. In Rome, the debate is over keeping Jewish festivals and food laws. In Corinth, the question is regarding meat sacrificed to another god.
- Social, civic, and religious gatherings are intertwined in Corinthian culture.
- Paul teaches that followers of Jesus are free to follow their conscience in debatable matters. However, love for our siblings should guide our decision.

Participation in the Body

1 Corinthians 8, 10, and 11:17-24 are all connected by the theme of what we’re participating in and why and the effect that has on those around us. *Koinonia* (Greek: *κοινωνία*—fellowship or participation) is the key concept.

Chapter 8 begins with “Now concerning ...”, so we know this is something they have raised with Paul in their letter: What do Christians do about food sacrificed to idols?

Background: Hellenistic, not Jewish

This is a different situation from the one in Rome regarding the “weak” and the “strong,” which related to people who kept food laws and observed Jewish festivals and special days and people who didn’t. The “strong” believed that those who thought they needed to observe the food laws etc. were “weak.”

Paul addresses this question in his letter to the Romans. The situation in Rome is related to the freedom that Christians have from food laws and religious customs (cf. Acts 10:9-16; Col. 2:16, 20-23; 1 Tim. 4:1-4).

In 1 Corinthians, we are dealing with the question of meat that has been sacrificed as an offering to a god in a ceremony to honor the god (Greek: *thusia/θύσια*). In these ceremonies, the animal would be killed, and some would be burned, some eaten, some put on a table for the god themselves, or some sold at the meat market.

These ceremonies happened at parties and feasts to which sometimes people would be invited by the god themselves! Sarapis and Isis were two gods who would have been worshiped in Corinth.

Gatherings

It’s also important for us to note that the social, civic, and religious gatherings were all intertwined. Business, networking, religious, and political agendas were all rolled into one, and you couldn’t tease them apart.

The important feasts or parties were where you wanted to be seen, where you would make business deals and friends, gain patrons, or honor patrons. It would be a huge loss of face and of opportunity for Christians not to be there. However, to go along meant participating in a pagan ceremony, and on occasions there would be flagrant sexual immorality.

What did people themselves think they were doing when they went to these ceremonies in relation to the god? We are not sure, but here are some options.

- Sacramental: taking part in the deity
- Communal: sharing a meal with the deity
- Social: eating a meal before the deity (See Willis, [Idol Meat in Corinth](#), 18-20)

These are about different levels of participation.

Paul at Odds With the Corinthians

Paul appears to take a sacramental view in chapter 10 but not in chapter 8. Does Paul think that idols are nothing or that they have some kind of demonic significance? ([Isa. 44:9](#) says, "All who make idols are nothing." There are many references in the Hebrew Bible about the uselessness of idols.) Or do we simply hold two views in tension with one another here?

1 Corinthians 8:1-8 NIV

¹ We know that "We all possess knowledge." But knowledge puffs up while love builds up. ² Those who think they know something do not yet know as they ought to know. ³ But whoever loves God is known by God.

⁴ So then, about eating food sacrificed to idols: We know that "An idol is nothing at all in the world" and that "There is no God but one." ⁵ For even if there are so-called gods, whether in heaven or on earth (as indeed there are many "gods" and many "lords"), ⁶ yet for us there is but one God, the Father, from whom all things came and for whom we live; and there is but one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom all things came and through whom we live.

⁷ But not everyone possesses this knowledge. Some people are still so accustomed to idols that when they eat sacrificial food they think of it as having been sacrificed to a god, and since their conscience is weak, it is defiled. ⁸ But food does not bring us near to God; we are no worse if we do not eat, and no better if we do.

1 Corinthians 10:14-22 NIV

¹⁴ Therefore, my dear friends, flee from idolatry. ¹⁵ I speak to sensible people; judge for yourselves what I say. ¹⁶ Is not the cup of thanksgiving for which we give thanks a participation in the blood of Christ? And is not the bread that we break a participation in the body of Christ? ¹⁷ Because there is one loaf, we, who are many, are one body, for we all share the one loaf.

¹⁸ Consider the people of Israel: Do not those who eat the sacrifices participate in the altar? ¹⁹ Do I mean then that food sacrificed to an idol is anything, or that an idol is anything? ²⁰ No, but the sacrifices of pagans are offered to demons, not to God, and I do not want you to be participants with demons. ²¹ You

cannot drink the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons too; you cannot have a part in both the Lord's table and the table of demons.²² Are we trying to arouse the Lord's jealousy? Are we stronger than he?

More Slogans?

What if the quotation was extended here? Wendell Lee Willis thinks that the whole of verses 4-7 might be a quotation. If this is the case, it would justify their eating the food.

1 Corinthians 8:7-8 NIV

⁷ But not everyone possesses this knowledge. Some people are still so accustomed to idols that when they eat sacrificial food they think of it as having been sacrificed to a god, and since their conscience is weak, it is defiled. ⁸ But food does not bring us near to God; we are no worse if we do not eat, and no better if we do.

Who are “the Weak” and Why?

“While it is not provable, it is likely that the term ἀσθενής [weak] was applied to some Christians who were troubled by eating εἰδωλοθύτων [things sacrificed to idols] by those who made much of so doing. Those who wrote to Paul probably raised the use of συνείδησις [conscience] and also probably originated the designation of some as ἀσθενής [weak]. The idea of ἡ συνείδησις ἀσθενής [a weak conscience] was a slur at those who refused to eat idol sacrifices, or who did so with troubled consciences. This means the real definition of the ‘weak’ in Corinth is ‘those not having knowledge.’”

Willis, Wendell Lee (1985). [Idol Meat in Corinth](#). Wipf and Stock. 94.

“Food will not commend us to God; we are no worse off if we do not eat it and no better off if we do’ (1 Cor. 8:8). This seems to place food in the category of ‘indifferent things’, like the Stoic notion of adiaphora, things that might be preferable in certain circumstances but fundamentally do not matter either way.”

Barclay, John M.G. (2010). “Food, Christian Identity and Global Warming.” *The Expository Times*, 121 (12). 587.

Paul’s Views or the Corinthian Views or Both?

It could be that the Corinthian leaders were mocking the “weak” whose consciences wouldn’t allow them to eat the food sacrificed to idols. Did they think that *gnosis* (knowledge) had the power to liberate them and protect them? Was it their freedom and guarantee that they would not be affected by the idol meat?

Whatever we decide about the quotations, Paul’s final position is that love trumps knowledge. Paul contrasts knowledge and love, and he is clear with them that sinning against a “weak” brother or sister is, in fact, sinning against Christ.

Reflection Question

How would you describe Paul's response to the sacrificial meat controversy? What matters most to him throughout his instruction?